Would Rahul Gandhi join the Yatra? What would be the name of this Yatra? What would be the dates and the starting and end points of the Yatra?

It took several rounds of democratic discussions within the party to decide on all these aspects and more. Finally, the party publicly declared the Bharat Jodo Yatra, a padyatra across the length of India, starting from Kanyakumari and culminating in Kashmir. It was announced that Rahul Gandhi, along with selected Bharat yatris from across India, would walk the entire stretch of the geographical terrain, while state yatris would join as the Yatra crossed their respective states. While this preliminary information was circulated by the party through media and social media outlets, people within the party were anxiously waiting for the revelation of the Bharat yatri list. Finally, the moment of truth arrived and the list was released. I distinctly remember the joy and anticipation I felt when I saw my name on it. My feeling of resolve was further strengthened when friends and colleagues from across the country reached out to not just congratulate me, but also share their hopes and expectations of the Yatra.

Once the news had settled in, I started preparing for the Yatra. Organizing practical requirements such as clothes, shoes, medicines and other utilities was easy and done in a matter of days. What was more significant to me was to prepare myself physically and mentally, and to reconnect with my own thoughts to seek the right approach to undertake this journey. My friends had expressed concerns about me walking the entire length. They were right, as I was not used to walking 25 kilometres a day. But I distinctly remember that when I told my mother I would be walking with Rahul Gandhi from Kanyakumari to Kashmir, she simply asked, ‘Will you walk the entire 4,000 kilometres?’ And I instantly answered in the affirmative. At that moment, I knew that my commitment and resolve to complete this Yatra had taken root inside of me and that excitement had overpowered all my doubts.

I felt a similar emotion when I was booking tickets for Kanyakumari. Trains were full and flight tickets were skyrocketing. It was as if people across India were converging on Kanyakumari to participate in the Yatra. I managed to reach Kerala via Mumbai, after which we undertook a road